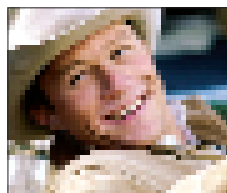




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Lead Feature

The ULTIMATE Gaming Guide

Gaming is a far better pastime than watching movies, and can be just as cinematic and riveting. But you've got to start somewhere, right? Here you go...

Agent 001

Does the word *gaming* remind you of happy hours spent in front of a Nintendo Game Boy, or does it make you fondly reminiscing with memories of late night *Quake 3* frag sessions? Does a pleasant game of *Spider Solitaire* relax you? Maybe you like to remember yourself poised with a twitchy finger curled around the trigger of your carbine with an enemy's skull in your sights? Gaming brings different levels of satisfaction in different ways to different people and though we Indians are well and truly on the gaming bandwagon, our journey into the realm of interactive entertainment has just begun.

For me, gaming began with classics like *Art of Fighting*, *Contra*, *Mario*, and *Spartan*. The move to PC gaming came around with classics like *Doom*, *Quake* and *Diablo* on an old Pentium 2 machine, and it's been a move from whence there's no return.

But that was in the late nineties—today's gaming market has evolved tenfold. For one, there are more options available. Two—

upgrading your PC isn't the headache it used to be. Three—a lot of consoles vie for your attention—the Xbox, Xbox 360 (X360), PlayStation 2 (PS2), PlayStation 3 (PS3) and Wii, and even handheld consoles like the PlayStation Portable (PSP). In fact, getting into gaming can be daunting for the sheer variety of choice. Not all of us can afford a super-PC, an X360 and a PS3 with a 50-inch plasma screen—resources are limited, and a decision has to be made. If anything, the fact that your cash is going to be spent on leisure rather than work, education or productivity will ensure that your budget is even skimpier. And for good reason too—while spending on a gaming setup, it's all too easy to lose your sense of financial decorum.

Unlike music—where one piece of equipment plays all kinds of music equally well—there's another variable. The platform you choose—PC or console—is going to affect your gaming experience with different genres of games. What plays well on a PC may not play well on a

console, and vice versa. Again, remember that you will probably migrate to different genres as you get more and more involved with gaming. You may, for example, start with racing games and get hooked on FPSes after playing a couple of them, or RPGs may start to interest you. In my opinion, both PC and console make equally good gaming boxes, and which one suits you largely depends on the genre of game.

Speaking of which...

The Genres Explained Shooters

This is the most popular genre. Such games have, (in general), much easier learning curves, and



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